

CRANK Observer Onboarding Guide

Visibility without authority. Silent in the room, useful after it.

THE ROLE IN ONE SENTENCE

Observers are a concession to organizational reality -- sometimes people need visibility into a team's work without holding authority over it. You attend the Stakeholder KICK only. You are strictly silent during the velocity and steer blocks, and you cannot introduce new requirements or direction changes in the room. Your feedback goes to the Stakeholder after the session, not into the meeting itself.

WHERE YOU SHOW UP IN THE FLYWHEEL

Phase	Your role
Charge / Run / Assess / Navigate	Not involved -- these are internal or Stakeholder-facing sessions you do not attend.
Dev KICK	Not involved -- internal to CRANK Lead and Developers.
Stakeholder KICK	Informed -- you attend, watch, and listen. You do not steer or decide.

WHAT "SILENT" ACTUALLY MEANS

Silent does not mean passive disengagement -- it means the room's decision-making stays clean. During the velocity and steer blocks, you do not speak, ask questions that redirect the conversation, or signal approval or disapproval that could be read as a decision. If something you hear concerns you, hold it and raise it with the Stakeholder after the session -- not in the room, where it could be mistaken for input from someone with real authority.

The moment an Observer starts steering the conversation, the room stops being able to tell who actually holds decision authority -- which is exactly the ambiguity the role exists to avoid.

WHAT YOU'RE ACTUALLY THERE TO DO

- Watch the live demo, when one happens, so you have direct visibility into real progress -- not a secondhand summary.
- Listen to the velocity block: real numbers on cycle time, ship rate, and blockers, not a narrative pitch.
- Notice anything that seems off -- a missed priority, a concerning trend, a gap between what was asked for and what's being built -- and raise it with the Stakeholder afterward.
- Stay out of the Escalation Path and Q&A blocks unless directly and explicitly invited in by the CRANK

Lead or Stakeholder.

- At the Governed pace setting, the Stakeholder KICK adds formal release sign-off. Observers stay silent through it -- sign-off belongs to Stakeholders with authority.

COMMON OBSERVER MISTAKES

- Asking a clarifying question mid-meeting that functions as a redirect -- even framed as "just curious," it can be read as steering.
- Reacting visibly to a decision in a way that pressures the Stakeholder one direction or another.
- Raising a new requirement or scope idea in the room instead of holding it for after the session.
- Skipping the after-session feedback to the Stakeholder because nothing felt urgent in the moment -- small observations compound and are worth passing along.

SUCCESS INDICATORS

- Nobody in the Stakeholder KICK has ever had to wonder whether you hold decision authority.
- You consistently pass useful observations to the Stakeholder after the session, not just when something goes wrong.
- Your presence has never once shifted the outcome of a Steer or Escalation Path decision.